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the Norwegian Nobel Committee nominating Trump for the Nobel Peace Prize. Yet, many strategists think it's too early to be praising Trump as the truce remains tenuous. "This is a pause, not a breakout of peace," says Syed Akbaruddin, India's former Permanent Representative to the UN and an expert on the Middle East. "It is a first step in a long, long road because none of the fundamental issues that caused the conflict, including Iran's nuclear prowess, have been adequately addressed."

A Fragile Peace

So, what triggered the current round of bloodletting and why is the truce so brittle? On June 13, when Israel launched its fiercest-ever attack on Iran, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu justified it by claiming that Tehran was months away from developing a nuclear weapon. This despite International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) chief Rafael Grossi denying such claims. However, his agency had voiced concerns about Iran's 2021 decision to enrich a portion of its uranium fuel stockpile to 60 per cent, pushing it closer to nuclear weapon-grade purity. Israel felt emboldened to strike Iran at this time because, as Mohan Kumar, a former Indian ambassador and currently Professor of Diplomatic Practice at the Jindal School of International Affairs, puts it, "With the active help of the US in the past two years, Israel had defenestrated with great success Iran's proxies in the region." This includes the Hamas, which carried out horrific terror attacks on October 7, 2023; the Hezbollah in neighbouring Lebanon; and the Houthis in Yemen. Israel also played a role in the sudden exit of the Iranian ally, Bashar al-Assad, in Syria.

From June 13 onwards, Israel unleashed a barrage of 200 missiles in air strikes that substantially dismantled Iran's military and nuclear infrastructure, and caused more than 950 casualties. In retaliation, Iran fired more than 500 ballistic missiles and launched over a thousand drones against Israel. Although Tel Aviv repulsed most of them, a few missiles got past its famed Iron Dome. However, in a country only slightly larger than Mizoram, India's fifth smallest state, its 10 million people are densely packed, and the missiles damaged civilian infrastructure and reportedly caused more than 28 deaths.

Initially, Trump had seemed undecided on joining forces with Israel against Iran since many of his top MAGA (Make America Great Again) backers were against any US involvement in foreign wars. Trump had come to power on the back of a campaign in which he promised that US troops would not be entangled in "forever wars". After he assumed office in January, Trump got his team to begin diplomatic negotiations with Iran, setting a stiff deadline of two months ending June 12 for it to reach an agreement with the US to dismantle any nuclear weapons capability it possessed. Despite five rounds of negotiations, the two sides failed to arrive at a deal by D-day. The very next day, Israel launched its massive strikes against Iran.

The Bunker Buster Strategy

Trump didn't seem inclined to join the war but caught most by surprise when he took the huge gamble of authorising 'Operation Midnight Hammer' to permanently defang Iran's nuclear prowess on June 22. That mission saw seven US Air Force B2 stealth bombers take off from American bases, refuel mid-air on their 37-hour journey to Iran and back, and carry out precision strikes with 14 GBU-57A Massive Ordnance Penetrators or MOPs, the mother of all bombs, on three of Iran's key nuclear facilities. The bunker buster bombs, as they are called, are designed to penetrate depths of up to 60 metres before exploding, and were dropped to target Iran's deeply buried Fordow enrichment facility as well as another at Natanz, while a third site in Isfahan was attacked with as many as 30 submarine-launched Tomahawk missiles. This is the first time since 1988—when the US navy destroyed an Iranian warship and blew up two of its oil platforms—that America had carried out a significant military strike on the Islamic republic.

Trump declared the US strikes on Iran's nuclear facilities to be "a spectacular military success" and claimed that its "key nuclear enrichment facilities have been totally obliterated". Having achieved America's objective of destroying Iran's nuclear enrichment capacity, Trump saw no value in continuing the conflict and forced both Israel and Iran to agree to halt hostilities. Israel, too, claimed that it had dealt a death blow to Iran's nuclear ambitions and repulsed its ballistic missile threats. Even as he thanked Trump for his support, a trium-